

European Chemicals

Air Products & Chemicals Inc

Rating

Outperform

Price Target



373.00 USD (345.00 OLD)



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Air Products 3QFY26: Passing the duck test

Air Products again delivered a solid update ([Quick Take: Air Products 3QFY26 - Another beat and raise quarter](#)). More of these quarters would go some way to fulfilling our thesis set out in our recent deep dive: [Air Products: Sustainable above-consensus EPS growth, even including NEOM](#). The quarter provides more evidence that Air Products is focusing on being an industrial gas company, and we continue to struggle to explain the historically large valuation gap versus industrial gas peers. We believe Air Products passes the “duck test”, but for industrial gas companies - if it mostly sells industrial gas and performs like an industrial gas company, then it probably is an industrial gas company. And should be valued like one. Outperform.

No NEOM headwind in expected in FY2027. As part of [our deep dive](#), we made a proprietary NEOM model, which remains available to clients on request. We make minor updates to bring the model in line with management guidance for FY27, of no major financial impact, which we have done by slowing the full commissioning of the facility, and therefore the project finance ramp. Therefore, our FY27 EPS forecast increases, and this addresses part of the investor bear case.

The pace of EPS growth may decline slightly yoy in FY27, but we still see an opportunity for compounding. APD has had some assistance from China gasification projects in delivering FY26’s likely 11-12% Adj. EPS growth. The volume environment will likely remain highly uncertain. The helium headwind will likely persist (but declining) until a large US contract rolls over next February. But none of these things take away from the productivity opportunity, or the ongoing ramp up of more electronics lines in Asia, or the ability to use pricing, particularly in the space business when a key customer repairs their launch pad. However, part of being an industrial gas company is guiding conservatively, so in order to pass the duck test investors may need to prepare for an opening ~6-9% yoy Adj. EPS FY27 guidance range. Which hopefully improves as the business executes.

Investment Implications

We rate Air Products Outperform. We raise both our FY26E and FY27E EPS by 1%. We roll our valuation framework from a FY26 P/E to a NTM P/E incorporating 3 months of FY26 and 9 months of FY27 EPS. On an unchanged multiple of 26x NTM P/E, our price target increases to \$373 from \$345.

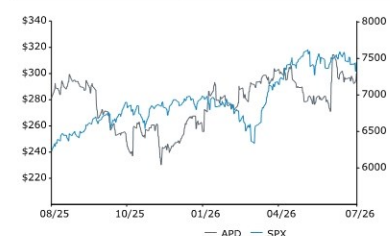
Adjusted EPS	F25A	F26E	F27E	Financials	F25A	F26E	F27E	CAGR	Valuation Metrics	F25A	F26E	F27E
APD (USD)	12.07	13.45	14.67	EBIT (M)	2,865	3,191	3,510	--	Adjusted P/E (x)	24.4	21.9	20.1
OLD	--	13.28	14.50						EV/EBITDA (x)	17.1	15.8	14.6

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

Close Date	29 Jul 2026			
APD Close Price (USD)	294.27			
Price Target (USD)	373.00			
Upside/(Downside)	27%			
52-Week Range	314.87/229.11			
SPX	7,437.63			
FYE	Sep			
Div Yield	2.4%			
Market Cap (USD) (M)	66,677			
EV (USD) (M)	86,583			
Performance	YTD	1M	6M	12M
Absolute (%)	21.2	2.1	9.9	3.2
SPX (%)	8.6	(0.8)	7.2	16.9
Relative (%)	12.6	3.0	2.7	(13.7)

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

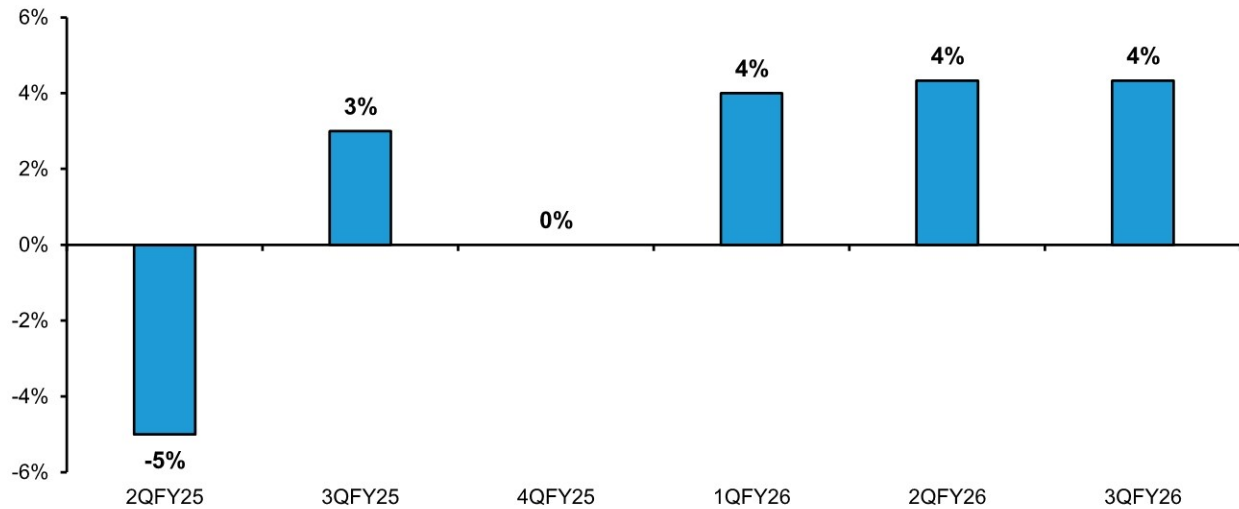
Price Performance, 1YR



DETAILS

EXHIBIT 1: Air Products are starting to build the results reliability investors prize from the industrial gases

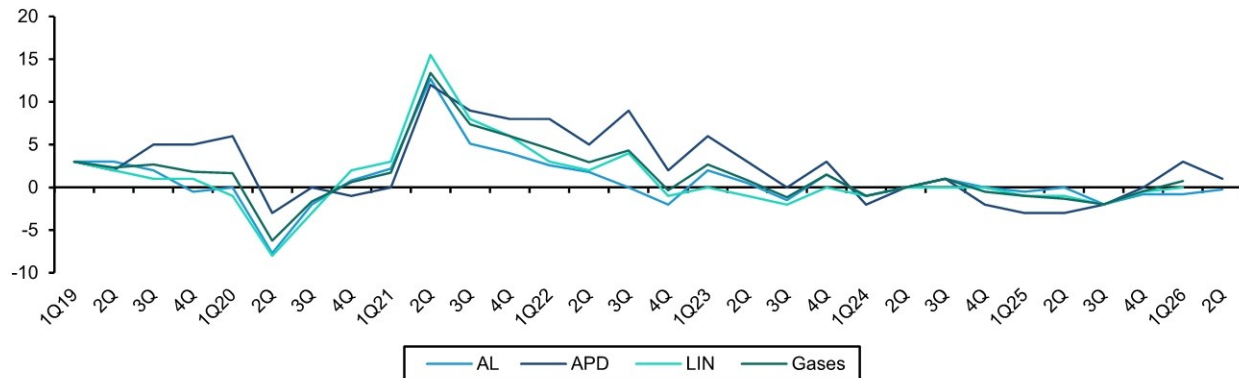
APD Adj. EPS beat / miss history under Eduardo Menezes



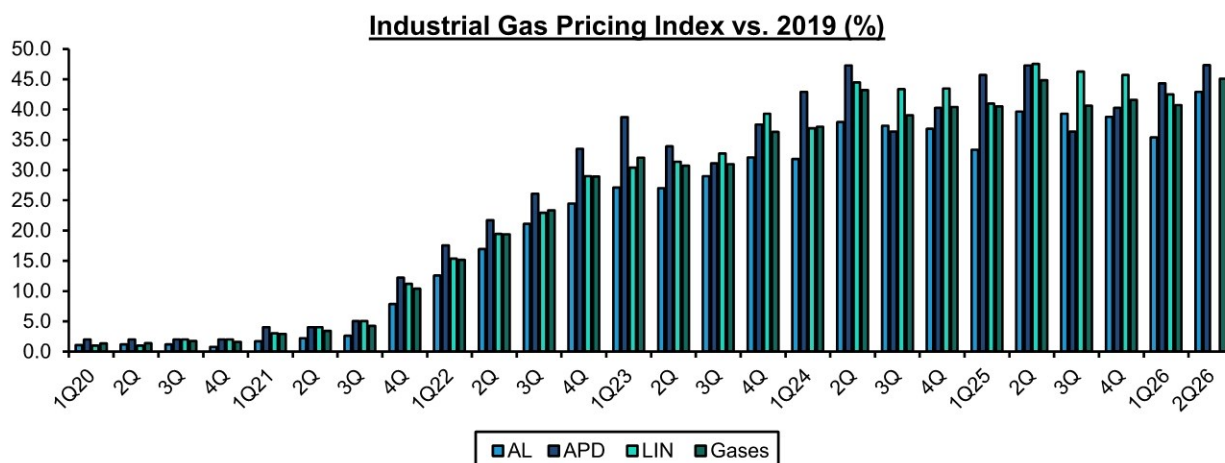
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 2: We believe base volumes continue to be positive at APD

Gas majors - base volume growth yoy 2019-2Q26 (%)

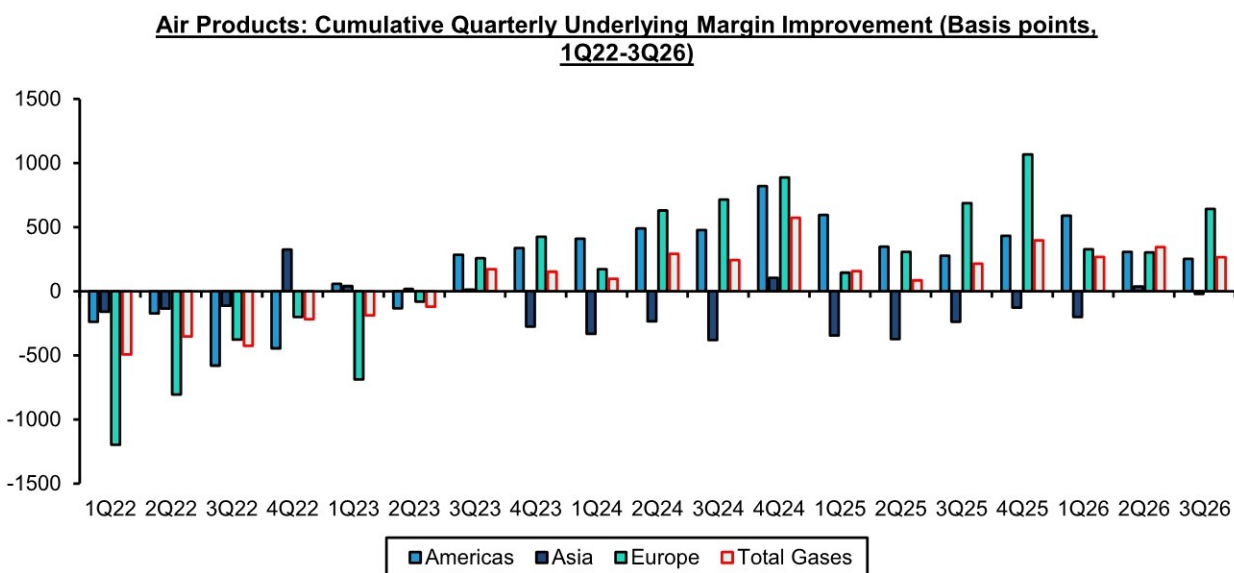


Source: Company information, Bernstein estimates and analysis

EXHIBIT 3: Air Products' merchant pricing continues to keep pace with peers despite helium headwinds

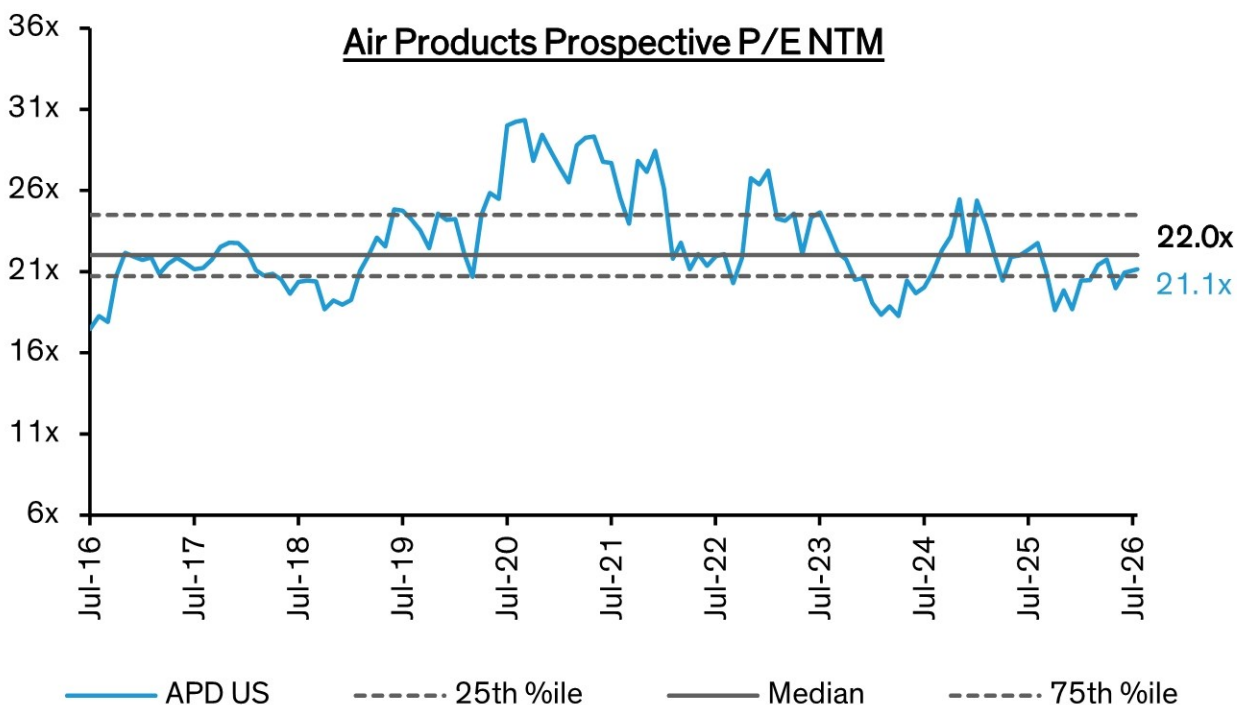
Calendar year quarters

Source: Company information, Bernstein analysis and estimates

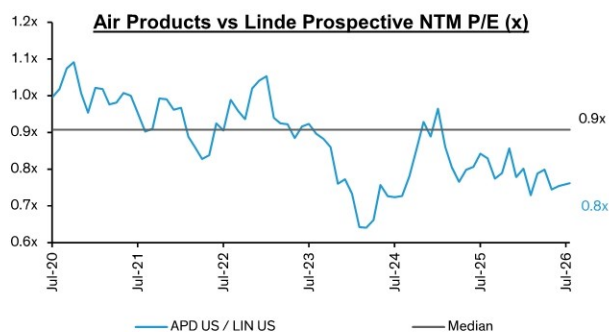
EXHIBIT 4: Recent margin progress is visible across all regions

Quarters use FY end of September

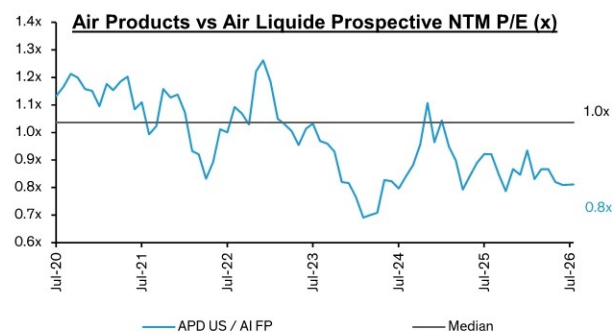
Source: Company data, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 5: **Air Products is currently trading near its 10-Y median**

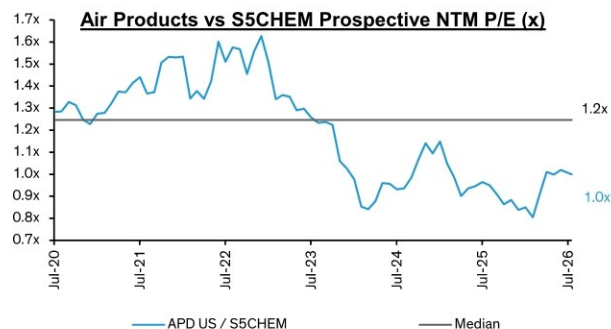
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 6: **Air Products' discount to peers has been widening over the past two years (1/2)**

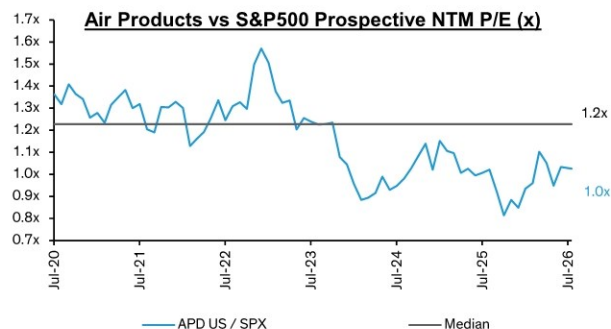
Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 7: **Air Products' discount to peers has been widening over the past two years (2/2)**

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 8: Air Products' relative valuation versus the sector remained at depressed levels since 2024...

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

EXHIBIT 9: ... and we see similar trend relative to the broader market

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein analysis

KEY INDUSTRIAL GASES RESEARCH**INDUSTRIAL GASES**

- 15 Jul 2026 - [Chemicals: Specialty or Commodity, with potentially tough times in between](#)
- 26 May 2026 - [The Long View: Chemicals - Analysing the lasting impact on upstream chemicals of the Iran war](#)
- 07 May 2026 - [The Bernstein Industrial Gases Primer: How the industry structure can support long-term outperformance](#)
- 20 Apr 2026 - [Chemicals: Positioning for an Iran-related cycle and upgrading Arkema to Market-Perform](#)
- 13 Mar 2026 - [Global Industrial Gases & Semis: Assessing the helium impact](#)
- 23 Feb 2026 - [The Long View: The Industrial Gas space opportunity - rocket fuel for growth](#)
- 08 Jan 2026 - [Chemicals Outlook 2026: A slow start, but there could be considerable upside potential. Downgrading Solvay to Market-Perform.](#)
- 01 Dec 2025 - [The Long View: How Industrial Gases revenues can compound at the magic 5% through 2030](#)
- 13 Aug 2025 - [European Chemicals: War and Peace II - Refreshing our Ukraine war scenarios](#)
- 27 May 2025 - [Chemicals: Amongst the tariff turmoil](#)
- 9 April 2025 - [Industrial Gas Majors - It's a big world, after all but gases don't travel so "Hold Tough" and Buy](#)

AIR PRODUCTS

- 17 Jul 2026 - [Air Products: Sustainable above-consensus EPS growth, even including NEOM](#)
- 30 Jun 2026 - [Quick Take: Air Products cancels Darrow & 3QFY26 update](#)
- 27 May 2026 - [Bernstein SDC: Air Products Takeaways](#)
- 01 May 2026 - [Air Products 2QFY26: This may not be the last guidance raise of the year](#)
- 02 Feb 2026 - [Air Products 1QFY26: Turnaround in Motion](#)
- 08 Dec 2025 - [Air Products gives a mega-project update: the industrial gas energy transition story is not over yet](#)

- 26 Nov 2025 - [Air Products 4QFY25: Making progress as focus moves to Darrow](#)
- 31 Jul 2025 - [Quick Take: APD 3Q25 - A first beat for new management](#)
- 1 May 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Products 2Q25 — a sobering update on the job in hand](#)
- 25 February 2025 - [Air Products - rapid megaproject rationalisation shows a renewed focus on shareholder value](#)
- 6 February 2025 - [Air Products - No surprises from the 1Q25 release](#)
- 4 February 2025 - [New leadership at Air Products to support density, discipline, de-risking and ... dependability](#)
- 31 January 2025 - [Air Products - Upgrading to outperform Density, discipline, de-risking...dependability?](#)

LINDE

- 05 May 2026 - [Linde 1Q26: Earnings Aristocrat, and potentially improving core growth](#)
- 19 Feb 2026 - [Linde 4Q25: Earnings Aristocrat, and well positioned for all macro scenarios](#)
- 3 Nov 2025 - [Linde 3Q25: Earnings Aristocrat, but also an underappreciated growth story](#)
- 31 Oct 2025 - [Quick Take: Linde 3Q25 - 27 Adj. EPS beats in a row, but a guidance narrow rather than raise](#)
- 4 Aug 2025 - [Linde 2Q25: Earnings Aristocrat](#)
- 1 Aug 2025 - [Quick Take: Linde 2Q25 - 26 EPS beats in a row, and what's 3 cents between friends?](#)
- 22 July 2025 - [Linde: Earnings aristocrat 2Q25 - we see the 26th quarter of consecutive EPS beats](#)
- 4 Jun 2025 - [Linde: A day with the CEO at the SDC - "The value is visible" ... in the field, networks, density, benchmarking, ownership, 45Q ...](#)
- 29 Apr 2025 - [Linde: Earnings Aristocrat? 1Q25 - we see the 25th quarter of consecutive EPS beat and underlying sequential growth](#)
- 6 February 2025 - [Linde - As expected the 24th beat, 1Q and FY25 guidance light and a share reaction like with 3Q24...](#)
- 4 February 2025 - [Linde - We see the 24th consecutive EPS beat, and qoq growth but the macro drag on guidance, but...](#)

AIR LIQUIDE

- 29 Jul 2026 - [Air Liquide 1H26 - Speed bump, but remain Outperform](#)
- 29 Apr 2026 - [Air Liquide 1Q26: Who is the guidance for?](#)
- 23 Feb 2026 - [Air Liquide 2H25: More growth and more margin improvement](#)
- 28 Jan 2026 - [Air Liquide: Best European Idea First Quarter 2026 – Improving growth that isn't priced in. Outperform](#)
- 03 Dec 2025 - [Quick Take: A day with Air Liquide at the SDC Premium Review](#)
- 29 Oct 2025 - [Air Liquide 3Q25: Typically solid, and potentially the growth trough](#)
- 25 Sep 2025 - [Air Liquide at the Bernstein European Industrials Forum: Reassuringly Consistent](#)
- 22 Aug 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Liquide acquires DIG Airgas - a high price, but a worthy purchase](#)

- 30 Jul 2025 - [Air Liquide 1H25: "This is just the beginning"](#)
- 28 Jul 2025 - [Air Liquide: Marginal Gains](#)
- 29 May 2025 - [Quick Take: Air Liquide Americas CEO at the SDC](#)
- 24 April 2025 - [Air Liquide - Steady as she goes](#)
- 21 February 2025 - [Air Liquide - Pushing the margin again...](#)
- 14 February 2025 - [Air Liquide- We see the FY24 EBIT margin +110bp and scope for c.500bp more from there](#)

APPENDIX - FINANCIAL FORECASTS

EXHIBIT 10: APD Summary P&L

Air Products (\$m)	FY23	yoy	FY24	yoy	FY25	yoy	4Q26e	yoy	FY26e	yoy	FY27e	yoy	FY28e	yoy
Sales														
Americas	5,369.3	0.0%	5,040.1	-6.1%	5,125.9	1.7%	1,366.6	8.4%	5,413.6	5.6%	5,792.5	7.0%	6,169.0	6.5%
Asia	3,216.1	2.3%	3,224.3	0.3%	3,271.0	1.4%	940.7	16.1%	3,490.8	6.7%	3,681.1	5.5%	3,865.1	5.0%
Europe	2,963.1	-4.0%	2,823.4	-4.7%	2,984.5	5.7%	799.9	3.8%	3,186.6	6.8%	3,303.9	3.7%	3,403.0	3.0%
Middle East	162.5	25.5%	134.4	-17.3%	135.9		32.6		126.9		556.1		1,002.3	
Gases	11,711.0	-0.1%	11,222.2	-4.2%	11,517.3	2.6%	3,139.9	9.0%	12,218.0	6.1%	13,333.5	9.1%	14,439.5	8.3%
Corporate & Other	889.0	-8.4%	878.4	-1.2%	520.0	-40.8%	172.6	20.8%	529.8	1.9%	500.0	-5.6%	500.0	0.0%
Group	12,600.0	-0.8%	12,100.6	-4.0%	12,037.3	-0.5%	3,312.5	9.6%	12,747.8	5.9%	13,833.5	8.5%	14,939.5	8.0%
Adjusted EBITDA														
Americas	2,198.2	15.6%	2,423.2	10.2%	2,408.7	-0.6%	660.1	9.2%	2,521.9	4.7%	2,784.5	10.4%	3,027.2	8.7%
Asia	1,369.7	0.9%	1,363.1	-0.5%	1,412.3	3.6%	419.0	18.7%	1,532.8	8.5%	1,638.4	6.9%	1,797.6	9.7%
Europe	962.1	23.9%	1,105.2	14.9%	1,194.0	8.0%	346.0	8.2%	1,314.2	10.1%	1,379.1	4.9%	1,471.5	6.7%
Middle East	394.2		380.0		376.4		99.8		401.0		378.3		362.2	
Gases	4,924.2	12.5%	5,271.5	7.1%	5,391.4	2.3%	1,524.9	10.7%	5,769.9	7.0%	6,180.4	7.1%	6,658.6	7.7%
Corporate & Other	-222.4		-225.2		-314.9	39.8%	-68.4	0.2%	-306.0		-256.0		-256.0	
Group	4,701.8	10.7%	5,046.3	7.3%	5,076.5	0.6%	1,456.5	11.2%	5,463.9	7.6%	5,924.4	8.4%	6,402.6	8.1%
Adjusted EBIT														
Americas	1,439.7	22.6%	1,565.1	8.7%	1,519.6	-2.9%	425.1	13.6%	1,598.2	5.2%	1,796.9	12.4%	1,975.4	9.9%
Asia	906.5	0.9%	859.2	-5.2%	851.1	-0.9%	273.2	26.0%	1,001.9	17.7%	1,074.9	7.3%	1,205.9	12.2%
Europe	663.4	31.8%	810.0	22.1%	844.7	4.3%	246.7	9.5%	912.5	8.0%	962.6	5.5%	1,042.5	8.3%
Middle East	16.9		5.9		9.6		6.7		25.1		6.4		-13.1	
Gases	3,026.5	16.5%	3,240.2	7.1%	3,225.0	-0.5%	951.7	15.5%	3,537.7	9.7%	3,840.8	8.6%	4,210.7	9.6%
Corporate & Other	-287.3		-292.7		-367.3	25.5%	-80.0	-3.7%	-346.5		-310.0		-310.0	
Operating Income	2,739.2	13.5%	2,947.5	7.6%	2,857.7	-3.0%	871.7	17.6%	3,191.2	11.7%	3,530.8	10.6%	3,900.7	10.5%
Adj Net Income	2,562.9	10.7%	2,768.6	8.0%	2,688.4	-2.9%	804.8	16.9%	2,997.6	11.5%	3,270.2	9.1%	3,566.0	9.0%
Dil Shares (m)	222.7		222.8		222.7		222.9		222.9		222.9		222.9	
Dil EPS \$	11.51	10.6%	12.43	8.0%	12.07	-2.9%	3.61	16.9%	13.45	11.4%	14.67	9.1%	16.00	9.0%
DPS \$	7.00	8.0%	7.08	1.1%	7.16	1.1%	1.81	1.1%	7.24	1.1%	7.35	1.5%	7.50	2.0%
EBITDA margin														
Americas	40.9%		48.1%		47.0%		48.3%		46.6%		48.1%		49.1%	
Asia	42.6%		42.3%		43.2%		44.5%		43.9%		44.5%		46.5%	
Europe	32.5%		39.1%		40.0%		43.3%		41.2%		41.7%		43.2%	
Middle East	NM		NM		NM		NM		NM		NM		NM	
Gases	42.0%		47.0%		46.8%		48.6%		47.2%		46.4%		46.1%	
Group	37.3%		41.7%		42.2%		44.0%		42.9%		42.8%		42.9%	
EBIT margin														
Americas	26.8%		31.1%		29.6%		31.1%		29.5%		31.0%		32.0%	
Asia	28.2%		26.6%		26.0%		29.0%		28.7%		29.2%		31.2%	
Europe	22.4%		28.7%		28.3%		30.8%		28.6%		29.1%		30.6%	
Middle East	10.4%		4.4%		7.1%		20.6%		19.8%		1.1%		-1.3%	
Gases	25.8%		28.9%		28.0%		30.3%		29.0%		28.8%		29.2%	
Group	21.7%		24.4%		23.7%		26.3%		25.0%		25.5%		26.1%	

Source: Company information, Bernstein estimates and analysis

EXHIBIT 11: APD Summary Cash Flow Metrics

Air Products	2020	2021	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026e	2027e	2028e
Op. Cash Flow/Sales	36.9%	32.3%	25.0%	25.4%	30.1%	22.3%	33.4%	34.7%	36.0%
Capex/Sales	28.3%	23.9%	36.1%	44.0%	56.2%	58.3%	31.3%	22.3%	17.7%
Capex (non-GAAP)/Sales	30.7%	24.7%	36.6%	41.5%	42.6%	42.1%	31.3%	22.3%	17.7%
Capex/depreciation	2.1x	1.9x	3.4x	4.1x	4.7x	4.5x	2.5x	1.8x	1.4x
Op. Profit/Capex	0.9x	1.0x	0.5x	0.5x	0.4x	0.4x	0.8x	1.2x	1.5x
Free Cash Flow (\$m)	756	871	-1,414	-2,332	-3,150	-4,336	264	1,665	2,580
Free Cash Conversion	34%	37%	-57%	-84%	-105%	-152%	8%	47%	67%
Net Debt (\$m)	1,550	1,836	4,271	8,357	11,243	15,842	15,156	14,919	13,802
Net Debt/EBITDA	0.4x	0.5x	1.0x	1.8x	2.2x	3.1x	2.8x	2.5x	2.2x

Source: Company information, Bernstein estimates and analysis

BERNSTEIN TICKER TABLE

Ticker	Rating	Cur	29 Jul 2026		TTM Rel. Perf.	Adjusted EPS				Adjusted P/E (x)		
			Closing Price	Price Target		Cur	2025A	2026E	2027E	2025A	2026E	2027E
APD (Air Products)	O	USD	294.27	373.00	(13.7)%	USD	12.07	13.45	14.67	24.4	21.9	20.1
OLD				345.00				13.28	14.50			
SPX			7,437.63									

PRICE TARGET CHANGE / ESTIMATE CHANGE IN BOLD

O - Outperform, M - Market-Perform, U - Underperform, NR - Not Rated, CS - Coverage Suspended

Source: Bloomberg, Bernstein estimates and analysis.

DISCLOSURE APPENDIX

I. REQUIRED DISCLOSURES

References to "Bernstein" or the "Firm" in these disclosures relate to the following entities: Bernstein Institutional Services LLC (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein & Co., LLC (pre April 1, 2024), Bernstein Autonomous LLP, BSG France S.A. (April 1, 2024 onwards), Sanford C. Bernstein (Hong Kong) Limited 盛博香港有限公司, Sanford C. Bernstein (Canada) Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein (India) Private Limited (SEBI registration no. INH000006378), Sanford C. Bernstein (Singapore) Private Limited, Sanford C. Bernstein Japan KK (サンフォード・C・バーンスタイン株式会社) and analysts employed by Société Générale Africa Technologies & Services to produce Bernstein research under a Global Services Agreement in place between Bernstein and Société Générale.

Bernstein is part of a joint venture between Société Générale (SG) and AllianceBernstein, L.P. (AB). Unless specifically noted otherwise, for purposes of these disclosures, references to Bernstein's "affiliates" relate to both SG and AB and their respective affiliates.

VALUATION METHODOLOGY**Air Products & Chemicals Inc**

We value the gas majors on prospective P/E and regard c.26x NTM26E P/E as appropriate for APD, hence our PT of \$373.

RISKS**Air Products & Chemicals Inc**

Downside – Setbacks in APD's mega-projects strategy continue notably in terms of uncertainties associated with the market development, a supportive regulatory environment, and a continued lack of off-take customers for the key green NEOM and Louisiana blue hydrogen projects. Any fresh setback are likely to have a major impact on the share price (as seen in 2020/21 and 2023/24) and could see the shares down. Net debt/EBITDA is over 2.5x reflecting APD's capex on mega-projects, any sense its financial leverage is stretching too far is likely to result in investor concern, share price impact >\$10ps. While we see APD's established business as very resilient with >50% of sales in onsite-type operations but especially under a new CEO since February 2025 if APD was to badly miss EPS guidance relative to peers and see further operational performance setbacks this could hit the share price hard, share price impact >\$10ps.

RATINGS DEFINITIONS, BENCHMARKS AND DISTRIBUTION**EQUITY RATINGS DEFINITIONS****Bernstein brand**

The Bernstein brand rates stocks based on forecasts of relative performance for the next 12 months versus the S&P 500 for stocks listed on the U.S. and Canadian exchanges, versus the Bloomberg Europe Developed Markets Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index EUR (EDME) for stocks listed on the European exchanges and emerging markets exchanges outside of the Asia Pacific region, versus the Bloomberg Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index USD (JPL) for stocks listed on the Japanese exchanges, and versus the Bloomberg Asia ex-Japan Large and Mid Cap Price Return Index (ASIA) for stocks listed on the Asian (ex-Japan) exchanges - unless otherwise specified.

The Bernstein brand has three categories of ratings:

- Outperform: Stock will outpace the market index by more than 15 pp
- Market-Perform: Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/- 15 pp
- Underperform: Stock will trail the performance of the market index by more than 15 pp

Coverage Suspended: Coverage of a company under the Bernstein research brand has been suspended. Ratings and price targets are suspended temporarily, are no longer current, and should therefore not be relied upon.

Not Rated: A rating assigned when the stock cannot be accurately valued, or the performance of the company accurately predicted, at the present time. The covering analyst may continue to publish research reports on the company to update investors

on events and developments.

Not Covered (NC) denotes companies that are not under coverage.

Bernstein brand stock ratings are based on a 12-month time horizon.

Autonomous brand – common stocks

The Autonomous brand rates common stocks as indicated below. As our benchmarks we use the Bloomberg Europe 600 Financials Price Return Index (E600BK) and Bloomberg Europe Dev Mkt Financials Large and Mid Cap Price Ret Index EUR (EDMFI) index for developed European banks and Payments, the Bloomberg Europe 600 Insurance Price Return Index (E600IN) for European insurers, the S&P 500 and S&P Financials for US banks and Payments coverage, S5LIFE for US Insurance, the S&P Insurance Select Industry (SPSIINS) for US Non-Life Insurers coverage, the Bloomberg Emerging Markets Financials Large, Mid and Small Cap Price Return Index (EMLSF) for emerging market banks and insurers and Payments, and the Bloomberg Japan Financials Large & Mid Cap Price Return Index (JPFILM) for Japanese Financials. Ratings are stated relative to the sector (not the market).

The Autonomous brand has three categories of common stock ratings:

- Outperform (OP): Stock will outpace the relevant index by more than 10 pp
- Neutral (N): Stock will perform in line with the market index to within +/- 10 pp
- Underperform (UP): Stock will trail the performance of the relevant index by more than 10 pp

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Not Rated: A rating assigned when the stock cannot be accurately valued, or the performance of the company accurately predicted, at the present time. The covering analyst may continue to publish research reports on the company to update investors on events and developments.

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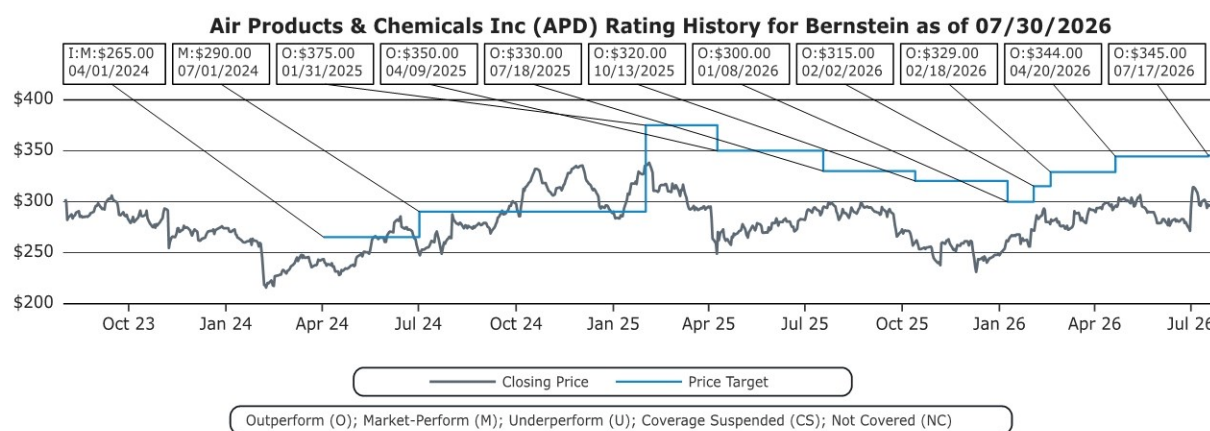
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